

KF14 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

As part of a research project, a group of children were placed in a situation of great temptation and then secretly observed.¹ They were told that they would receive a very desirable reward if they would wait for the facilitator to come back into the room before eating the treat in front of them. Some of the children did not have the skills to endure their craving for the treat; they could not bear the tension of waiting. As a result, those children chose the immediate gratification of their desires. Their inability to courageously wait prevented the possibility of a greater reward.

Other children, however, had endurance skills and were able to manage their tension. They were able to resist immediate gratification in order to discover what their desirable reward might be. They avoided looking at the treat, pulled on their hair, or wiggled out their tension until they reached their goal. They had learned methods of coping with their immediate cravings. Although they did not know if the promised reward would be worth it, they at least gave themselves the opportunity to find out. They practiced a kind of mindfulness that helped them stay the course no matter how they felt.

Your KF work requires lots of courageous endurance. When we change life patterns, there will be tension, but just like the children who endured, you can use your mindfulness training and tapping to manage that tension. By constructively enduring, you give yourself a chance to discover the rewards that are possible for you in Christ.

Let’s continue practicing the **SALT Process**.

1. S is for Skin

Take a mindfulness posture and breathe. *(Pause)* Focus your mind on your body. As you breathe, feel the air move in and out. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Your skin is a physical boundary. Notice how it provides a delineation between what is within and what is without. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Now, guide your attention to observe only what is within your skin, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. A is for Assess

Allow an event or situation to come to mind, one that you judge as evil. Observe how your body feels

when you think about that situation or event. *(Pause)* Is there tension, fatigue, restlessness, or something that you cannot describe? *(Pause)* Where in your body do you feel those sensations? *(Pause)* On a scale of one to ten, assess the intensity of what you are feeling, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. L is for Look

Look for the fear. Ask yourself and then ask God: *What threatens my Idol Self about this event or situation? What am I afraid of? Of loss . . . of others . . . or of myself?* *(Pause)* Step back from judging the event and just look at the fear behind the judgment. Observing the fear brings you valuable information about yourself and is part of the healing process. *(Pause)* You might try welcoming the fear and thanking it for what it is telling you about the quality of your faith, or trust in God. Thank the fear for its part in motivating you to grow. As you thank your fear, use a long exhaling breath, like a sigh. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

4. T is for Tell

Tell God about your fear. Talk to Him about what threatens you and about the stories that you attach to the fear. *(Pause)* Are your stories linked to the past or the future? Are they about what is fair or unfair, right or wrong? *(Pause)* Ask God to show you the truth about this situation and to replace your fear with the positive motivations of trust, hope, and love. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a few relaxing breaths and rest in the stillness for one minute. You may wish to take a sip of water and jot down a few notes about what you have learned. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause. Use the **SALT Process** this week, spending a minute or two on each step, and see what you can learn.

Our hymn and affirmation is *All the Way My Savior Leads Me*.

All the way my Savior leads me. Oh, the fullness of His love!
Perfect rest to me is promised in my Father's house above.
When my spirit, clothed immortal, wings its flight to realms of day,
This my song through endless ages: Jesus led me all the way;
This my song through endless ages: Jesus led me all the way.²

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

During this Toolbox training, you might want to have a **Shoulds Worksheet** available.

This month we are exploring KF Confession 3:

We constructed legal systems based on our own assessment of good and evil.

Our Idol's laws dictate how we should think and how we should act, and this list of laws, or legal standards,

supports our pride system. When we adhere to these standards, we feel superior and secure, but when we fail to achieve them, our pride is hurt, and we severely judge ourselves for whatever limitation is hindering us. These perceived failures and judgments are the source of our self-hate. We want to be the glorious Idol Self right now, and when we cannot be that, we hate ourselves. Frantic bravado is the Idol's substitute for enduring courage. We rush at restrictions with both barrels blazing, terrified of our own self-hate. Rushing at limitations and wrestling with them in our wrath and fear is like trying to stop a bullet with the power of our imagination. Real limitations will always win. Life has a way of crushing our neurotic pride, and hurt pride can drive us into the wrong pasture with the wrong bull.

Rather than using your precious energy to reassert and strengthen your pride system, why not use that same energy to disarm your shoulds and taboos? That would make the experience of your real limitations much less painful. After all, your legal systems simply foster judgment and self-hate and block your creativity. Is that really what you want?

The **Shoulds Worksheet** is designed to help you dismantle your legal systems and escape the tyranny of the shoulds. Make a few copies of this worksheet and keep them handy in your KF ring binder. When you are in the middle of wrestling and wrath and looking down the back of the accusing, craving bull that has just claimed you for the next dance, you won't have the presence of mind to print out worksheets. You will be too busy dancing! So, do yourself a favor and have a few worksheets ready to help you throw off the bull's control.

We recently learned to use the **Two Paths Flowchart** to help us understand how we create outcomes through our choices. The flowchart begins with an event, and here is something you may not realize: even self-hate is an event. Self-hate scares us, and when something scares us, we tend to judge it as evil. Many people get to this stage in their KF training and quit. The unconscious self-hate that they have been suppressing all of their lives begins to surface, and they start to feel strong emotions toward themselves and toward others. These emotions feel dangerous, and it seems safest just to quit this work. When members tell themselves that they have simply lost interest in their KF training, they may actually be avoiding the next challenge in their personal development and the inevitable self-hate. If you feel like quitting, I would encourage you to keep training not just for your own sake, but for that of others—and, especially, for the Lord.

Self-hate is an event that powerfully generates the fear of death. When we are in self-hate, we often don't realize it until we see the outcomes of chaos or self-sabotage. With practice, however, we can learn to recognize self-hate and choose to "believe it" rather than judge. Believing it begins with acknowledging our self-hate with compassion. We can then learn to endure the tension of our self-hate and practice long-tempered living. We can become mindful and observe. Judging is a hair-trigger, short-tempered reaction that requires no endurance. When we judge, we are no longer mindful; in a millisecond, we convince ourselves of how right or wrong we are and how right or wrong someone or something is. We make no real effort to understand another person, or the situation, or even to understand ourselves and our real limitations. We feel no compassion. No prayer for guidance is in our hearts. We simply react.

Even in the midst of self-hate, judgment, stories, and feelings, you can choose to realign yourself with love. However, most of us have trained our neuropaths to trigger our minds and bodies to take action without stepping on the brakes. Once you take action, there is no turning back; you have closed the door to love, and circulation stops. I'm very sorry to tell you this, but you really can ruin your own life and damage the lives of others. You can take paths that will irrevocably change the course of your life and that of others. It is simply the law of cause and effect generating outcomes from which there is no return.

You can learn to cooperate with God in your redemption, but if you have participated in extensive ruin, it will require long-term obedience to the Lord and a whole-hearted commitment to learn how to redirect your choices and, therefore, your whole life toward healthier outcomes.

Please take out your **Shoulds Worksheet**.

We will only explore Part One in this lesson. Part One helps us define what is real about ourselves at this moment.

1. Indicators and reactions

What have you done, thought, or felt that lets you know that you are no longer in peace? You may find yourself in chaotic outcomes, having anxious nightmares, battling obsessive thoughts and hurt feelings, or simply experiencing strain or tension. You might recognize compulsive cravings or behaviors, or perhaps you are trying to manage God's or someone else's business.

2. Identify your emotions

Use the list of feelings to help you map your emotional reactions. Circle or highlight the feelings that describe your experience. Write down any other feelings that you may be experiencing. Notice your body. Is it reacting to the situation? If so, how and where? You might ask yourself: *Am I chronically using my body to relieve anxiety?* Biting lips or nails, scratching or picking, gratifying a craving or addiction, and even sleeping too much may be an external expression of self-hate.

3. When and what?

Ask yourself: *When did I start feeling this way? Was there a specific event that I judged as bad or not good enough? What was that event?* For example, perhaps you started feeling this way when you saw your bank balance, showed someone mercy, or asserted your opinion.

Once we have identified what happened and when, we might be able to see that, without our being aware of it, our self-hate has been building up for some time. We may have actually generated this event to give ourselves a story about our unconscious self-hate. For example, we might hold the belief that unlimited funds would be good—it would support our neurotic glory. Daily reminders that we have financial limitations then trigger our unconscious self-hate, and we might react by overspending so that we can consciously feel that self-hate. We can then explain our feelings with the more comfortable story of overspending. This story is more comfortable because it allows the Idol to blind us to the real reason for our self-hate. If we know the real reason, we might do something about it, and the Idol can't risk that. The real reason for our self-hate is that we have run into a limitation. We might confess overspending as a sin, but there isn't any power in that confession because overspending is not the real sin. The real sin is our longing to be like God, having no limitations, not even the limitation of money.

4. Restoring comfort or pride

Most of us have learned what emotions and behaviors will immediately appease our Idol and indulge our cravings to return to old misoriented patterns that offer effortless gratification and release from the tension of endurance. These default patterns restore our pride but undermine our true potential and that of others.

Pride in an imagined ability to recover from disasters can make us reckless and unprepared. It may be hard to believe, but for some of us a kamikaze dive seems like the only way to relieve the tension.

When we are tempted to self-destruct, we urgently need skills that will help us recognize what is going on and then endure the tension of compulsive feelings while we use our tools to reorient.

Whenever we try to avoid discomfort and appease our Idol by giving into its demands, our real motive is to restore neurotic pride. Mastery types tend to grab control, create conflict, or conscript slaves. Self-effacing types suffer, lie, and accuse others while exaggerating their own helplessness. Resigned types can neglect responsibilities and resist change; they retreat to their stronghold of self-complacency and addictive escape.

I hope that by now you are tired of repeating the same destructive patterns of behavior. Remember that you become the Idol's prey when you choose to self-destruct. It's boring and wasteful to keep repeating the same patterns of self-harm. We might even be able to laugh at ourselves for being so boring! God and your True Self are remarkably creative and capable, and with God's help you can learn to mindfully process your self-hate and then train hard for your next opportunity. One day you will witness with delight an entirely different set of outcomes.

In our next lesson, I will continue guiding you through the **Shoulds Worksheet**. Take time to explore it further and bring your questions to the KF meeting. You might also talk to your Karis Link. I hope that you will be able to offer some of your experiences during the sharing time.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord Jesus, show me my shoulds. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let's look at Paul's letter to the Galatians, which you will find in the Bible right after Corinthians. You might read the full chapter or the entire letter and see how the alternative understanding from this meeting helps clarify Paul's teaching about legal systems. The Bible is one of your manuals for healing. You really do need to know what the Bible says if you hope to recover your True Self.

This month we are focusing on KF Confession 3:

We constructed legal systems based on our own assessment of good and evil.

Let me now introduce some information that you might find useful. The Greek word for *faith* can also be translated as *trust* and *trustworthiness*. Additionally, in the first verse of Hebrews chapter 11, we are taught that faith, or trustworthiness, is the evidence of an unseen reality. *Faith is living the kind of life that is trustworthy evidence of the reality and character of the unseen God. (Repeat)* This definition helps us understand what Paul means by faith in his letter to the Galatians.

Now let's read my paraphrase of **Galatians 2:16–21**.

¹⁶You know that no one orients by trying to fulfill legal systems of shoulds, taboos, and claims, judging good and evil. Instead, we orient through becoming the evidence of the unseen truth of Jesus Christ. And we have confidence in this truth, which gives us the courage to make life choices that reveal who He is. This confidence does not spring from fulfilling our legal systems for no one will ever be oriented through trying to fulfill legal systems.

¹⁷But if while seeking to be oriented in Christ, we discover also that we are terribly misoriented, does it mean that Christ is a servant of misorientation? Absolutely not! ¹⁸Let me explain. If I build again a legal system that I once destroyed, I re-partner with those who have missed the path. ¹⁹Think of it this way: through trying to have a relationship with my own legal system, I died to that system so that I might live in a trust relationship with God. I have been crucified with Christ on the cross of all legal systems. ²⁰And I, as the Idol Self, no longer live, but Christ lives in my True Self. And my real qualities, which were usurped by the Idol, have now become the evidence of the unseen character of the Son of God, who out of His great goodness loved me and took tremendous risks on my behalf. ²¹By living this new life, I do not dismiss or discount the value of God's *karis* gift, which invited me into relationship with Him. Think about this: if we are oriented through the efforts we make to fulfill our legal systems—by our shoulds, taboos, and claims—would Christ have died for us as a *karis* gift?

Take a deep breath.

Let me summarize this passage. As much as we wish it were possible, no one orients to God through the legal systems of shoulds, taboos, and claims. We orient to God by becoming the evidence of Jesus Christ in this world. This difficult process requires a lot of trust in Jesus, but our confidence in the process grows as our life reveals more and more of the truth about Him.

Now that we are in training, we may be struggling with our legal systems in a new way. In fact, trying to become more like Jesus can stir up more self-hate, but that isn't the fault of Jesus. It happens because we are trying to construct another system of laws for ourselves—based, perhaps, on being a “good” member of *Karis Fellowships*. But, as Christians, we can give up being motivated by legal systems altogether and learn how to live as Jesus did, in *karis* relationship with God. We are God's creatures, and when we humbly give up our legal systems, He can use all of our natural strengths and our training in *karis* relationship to express who He is. If God had wanted us to live by legal systems, would He have sent Jesus to die for us as a *karis* gift?

I would like to remind you that I'm not rewriting what the Apostle Paul wrote to fit my philosophies. Through my paraphrases, which are not literal translations, I am trying to show you how Paul's writings support our work in *Karis Fellowships*. We are so used to seeing certain English words that we are often blinded to their full meaning. I wonder if that is why our life choices don't change. We are constantly studying but fail to come face to face with the Biblical vision of the extraordinary life that is our true potential in Christ.

As you read the New Testament, you might begin noticing the words grace, faith, and righteousness. Grace comes from the Greek word *karis* (or *charis*). This is where we get the name of our fellowships. Grace can be understood as a gift that invites a relationship. This relationship only begins when the one who receives the gift responds with a gift. So, you might think of grace as a relationship built on mutual generosity. You

can look on the KF website for resources that describe the dynamic of grace.³ Faith can be translated as trust or trustworthiness, so you might think of faith as trust in someone or something and, equally, as the quality of trustworthiness in someone or something. When we are living in faith, we are trustworthy in our efforts to become the material evidence of the unseen reality of Jesus. The Greek word for righteousness is also the word for justice. Righteousness might be understood as orientation, or living in a just relationship with our Lord according to His way of doing things. Righteous people are the karis-abiding citizens of God's kingdom because they have responded to God's karis gift.

Understanding my Idol Self with its pride and legal systems and pursuing my karis relationship with God and my community has completely recharged and revitalized my understanding of what it is to be Christian. Through that understanding, I am empowered to refuse the Judgment Path and learn to love. I'm so happy to belong to a fellowship where we learn, explore, and grow together.

Our prayer might go something like this:

God of giving, teach me about my karis relationship with You. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider letting go of a should—what you should be or what you should do, what others should be or do, or what life should be or do according to your Idol's standards. (Repeat)*

Choose just one should that causes you to react with judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few phrases that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider letting go of this should*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush feelings and thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Breathe, and hold your experience up to the light as you *consider letting go of this should*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider letting go of this should*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what intense frustration or shutting down feels like in your body, or perhaps what hope or trust feels like. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider letting go of this should*. Does that feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge letting go of this should as good or evil? What are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Is this should a regular pattern in your life? Are you afraid of something—of loss, of missing out, of hating yourself, or perhaps, of discovering your real glory? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

For thousands of years, human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered letting go of their shoulds*. You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. *(Pause)* Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. You can observe and learn something from what you have just experienced. With training, you can choose what you will do with your feelings. *(Pause)* When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe with compassion for yourself and for all of us who are dealing with shoulds. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time to heal and train together. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our real glory and to the truth of who You created us to be. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Stanford_marshmallow_experiment.

² *All the Way My Savior Leads Me* by Fanny J. Crosby (1820–1915), www.youtube.com/watch?v=ekUELQnCnQIM.

³ DeSilva, David A. *Honor, Patronage, Kinship & Purity: Unlocking New Testament Culture*. Downers Grove: IVP Academic, 2000, theogeek.blogspot.com/2008/02/grace-mistranslated-word-and.html.